

BODY DECODE • STRESS AND CORTISOL

The Stress Reset

Five steps to put your cortisol rhythm back the right way round.

If you are wired at night and holding fat, you are probably fighting a rhythm.

Cortisol is meant to run on a curve. High in the morning to get you up, falling through the day, low at night so you can sleep.

When that curve flips, you get the version most people know too well. Flat in the morning, foggy through the afternoon, then weirdly switched on at 10pm. And your body holds on to fat while it happens, because as far as it is concerned the threat never ended.

Why you cannot train your way out of it. A rhythm is not a fitness problem. Adding a harder session to a body that is already running high is another demand on a system that needs fewer of them, not more.

You can reset the rhythm though, and it does not take much. Five steps, all free, all starting today.

1 Anchor the morning

Eat something within an hour of waking.

This is the one that does the most and gets skipped the most. Food in the morning tells the curve where its peak belongs. Skip it and cortisol has no anchor, so it drifts later, which is exactly the problem you are trying to fix.

It does not need to be big. It needs to have protein in it.

2 Front-load the hard stuff

Do the demanding, stressful things earlier in the day.

Difficult conversations, hard training, the task you have been avoiding. A body already running high on cortisol does not need a fresh spike at 7pm on top of the day it has already had.

Same work. Earlier. That is the whole change.

3 Build a hard stop

Pick one fixed thing that ends the workday, and do it every day.

A walk. A shower. Changing out of work clothes. It does not matter which, it matters that it is the same one and it happens every day.

Your body needs a signal that the threat is over. Without one, the workday never formally ends and cortisol never gets told to stand down.

4 Dim the last hour

Drop the lights sixty to ninety minutes before bed.

Light is a cortisol input. Bright rooms late tell your body it is still daytime, so cortisol stays up and melatonin cannot rise.

Big lights off, lamps on. That is enough to matter.

5 Protect the bookends of sleep

No screens in the last hour before bed. No phone in the first hour after waking.

The start and end of sleep do the most repair, and they are the two windows most easily wrecked. Picking up your phone before you are properly awake starts your day on someone else's agenda and spikes cortisol before you have even stood up.

TRY THIS WEEK

Pick the two of these five that you could genuinely do every day this week. Not the two that sound most impressive. The two you will actually do.

Most people find the wired-at-night feeling eases first, usually within about a week, and before anything at all shows up on the scale.

That is the point. The rhythm shifts before the body does, so the first sign this is working is how your evenings feel, not what you weigh.

This is the mini version, and it is aimed at one pattern. If stress and cortisol are not what is actually driving your storage, these five steps will make you feel better and will not do much to your body composition, because they are aimed at something else.

Worth knowing which you are dealing with before you spend three months on it.

IS STRESS ACTUALLY WHAT IS DRIVING YOURS?

The free **14-Day Body Decode Challenge** asks you some questions on day one, checks eight things against your own starting point on day seven, and tells you your pattern on day fourteen. Which of the four is running yours, and what to do about that specific one.

Free. Nothing to pay to get your read.

bodyrecode.au/challenge

The full **Sleep Reset Protocol** goes deeper on the whole rhythm, at bodyrecode.au/store